

contain approximately the same quantity of volatile oil. Nonetheless, Romanian research indicates that the Asian species contains a much wider range of therapeutically active antiseptic compounds.

History & Folklore Honeysuckle is one of the Bach Flower Remedies, and in this system of herbal cures it is believed to counter feelings of nostalgia and homesickness. *Jin yin hua* has long been used in Chinese medicine to “clear heat and relieve toxicity.”

Medicinal Actions & Uses Honeysuckle flowers from both species can be successfully used to treat fever, colds, and upper respiratory tract infections. The leaves are traditionally used as a gargle for sore throats and as a mouthwash. In Chinese herbal medicine, honeysuckle finds frequent use in inflammatory conditions, such as conjunctivitis, mastitis (inflammation of the breasts), and rheumatism.

Research Chinese research indicates that the Asian species has significant antimicrobial activity, including against the tuberculosis bacillus. Clinical studies suggest that this species can also help to lower high blood pressure.

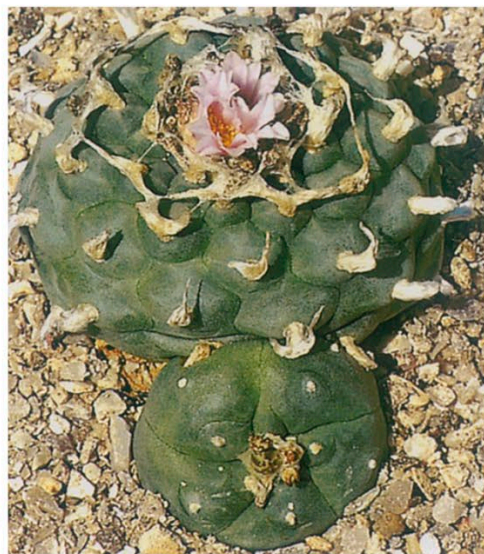
Caution Do not eat the berries, which are thought to be toxic.

Lophophora williamsii (Cactaceae) Peyote

Description Cactus growing to 2 in (5 cm). Has a squat gray-green body with tufted hairs, and pink or white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Peyote is native to northern Mexico and the southwestern region of the U.S.

Part Used Whole plant.



Peyote is a powerful hallucinogen. It is used in Native American ceremonies.

Constituents Peyote contains alkaloids, principally mescaline, which is a powerful hallucinogen.

History & Folklore Peyote has been used in Native American religious ceremonies for over 3,000 years. Its use as a hallucinogen was popularized by Aldous Huxley in his book *The Doors of Perception*.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Peyote is a shamanistic plant, taken in Native American rituals to deepen spiritual understanding. It plays an important part in the emotional and mental state of the community. It is also used to treat fevers, as a painkiller for rheumatism, and to treat paralysis. It is applied as a poultice for fractures, wounds, and snake bite. Peyote is also used to induce vomiting.

Caution The use of peyote and mescaline is illegal in most countries.

Luffa cylindrica syn. *L. aegyptica* (Cucurbitaceae)

Loofah, Si Gua Luo (Chinese)

Description Annual vine climbing to 49 ft (15 m). Has large lobed leaves, tendrils, and yellow female flowers producing long cylindrical marrow-like fruit.



Loofah fruit is dried and used in Chinese medicine to treat muscle and joint pain.

Habitat & Cultivation Loofah is native to the tropics of Asia and Africa. It is now grown as a fruit in tropical regions around the world. It is harvested when ripe in summer.

Part Used Fruit.

Constituents Loofah contains polysaccharides, xylan, xylose, and galactan.

History & Folklore Loofah was brought from India to China in the Tang Dynasty (618–907 CE).

It is best known in the West as a bathroom accessory—the fibrous skeleton makes a good skin scrubber.

Medicinal Actions & Uses In Chinese medicine, the inner skeleton of the dried fruit is used to treat pain in the muscles, joints, chest, and abdomen. It is prescribed for chest infections accompanied by fever and pain, and is used to clear congested mucus. Loofah is also given to treat painful or swollen breasts.

Research Chinese research indicates that the fresh vine has a stronger expectorant effect than the dried fruit. German research (1999) using a homeopathic preparation of the plant showed it to be as effective as a standard nasal spray for relief of hay fever.

Lycopodium clavatum (Lycopodiaceae) Club Moss

Description Creeping evergreen moss growing to 4¾ in (12 cm). Has numerous straggling branchlets covered with bright green linear leaves, and scaly spikes bearing yellow spores.

Habitat & Cultivation Club moss is found throughout temperate regions of the northern hemisphere. It is common on mountains and in moorland. The plant is gathered in summer.

Parts Used Moss, spores.

Constituents Club moss contains about 0.1–0.2% alkaloids (including lycopodine), polyphenols, flavonoids, and triterpenes.

History & Folklore Club moss has been used medicinally since at least the Middle Ages. The whole plant was employed as a diuretic to aid in the flushing out of kidney stones. In Wales, club moss was used for certain back problems and for colds and sore throats. Being strongly water-resistant, the spores are still used to coat tablets. The spores ignite explosively and have been used in making fireworks.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Club moss is diuretic, sedative, and antispasmodic, and is particularly useful for treating chronic urinary issues. The herb may also be taken for indigestion and gastritis. The spores can be applied to the skin to relieve itchiness. Club moss is frequently used in homeopathic medicine, being prescribed for headache, liver problems, and digestive symptoms such as gas and burping.

Caution Club moss is potentially toxic in overdose. This plant should only be used with the supervision of a professional practitioner.



Club moss